



Cairo

Egypt



Area 175 sq miles (453 sq km)

Population 7.2 million

Founding date 969 CE

Although it is near several ancient Egyptian sites, including the pyramids of Giza, Cairo itself was founded on the Nile River by the Islamic Fatimid dynasty in the 10th century. The “city of a thousand minarets” is famous for its Islamic architecture, but it is also a vibrant modern city—the political and cultural capital of Egypt.

Rome

Italy



Area 505 sq miles (1,308 sq km)

Population 2.8 million

Founding date 753 BCE

The capital of Italy, Rome was once the capital of the Roman Empire, which controlled Europe for more than 500 years until 476 CE. Today, its rich heritage of ancient Roman, medieval, and Renaissance architecture attracts visitors from all over the world.

Paris

France



Area 41 sq miles (105 sq km)

Population 2.2 million

Founding date Before 52 BCE

Famous as one of the most romantic cities in the world, Paris is the capital and cultural center of France. The city lies at the heart of one of the largest urban areas in Europe, home to 12 million people, and the whole region is responsible for more than a quarter of France’s national wealth.

Moscow

Russian Federation



Area 969 sq miles (2,510 sq km)

Population 11.5 million

Founding date Before 1147

Moscow lies farther north than any of the world’s other great cities, and is noted for its very long, cold winters. Despite this, it is Russia’s largest city and the sixth-largest in the world. At its center lies the medieval fortress of the Kremlin, which is still the center of government today.

Beijing

China



Area 6,336 sq miles (16,410 sq km)

Population 19.6 million

Founding date 1045 BCE

Beijing has been the capital of China for most of its 3,000-year history. The imperial palace, known as the Forbidden City, is a spectacular complex of 980 medieval buildings hidden behind huge stone walls. The surrounding city is one of the largest in the world, and the political and cultural hub of the nation.

London

United Kingdom



Area 607 sq miles (1,570 sq km)

Population 8.3 million

Founding date 43 CE

Founded by the Romans soon after their invasion of Britain, London was sited near the mouth of the Thames River. It was a major port for many centuries, and is still

one of the world’s leading financial, cultural, and educational centers. The capital is home to about 12 percent of the UK population, with more than 300 languages spoken there.

